



KNOW HOW



Q I have heard that all computers with an on-board LAN card have a unique MAC address. Please let me know what this MAC address is and how to check it on my desktop.

—Nilima Sharma, Agra

MAC is an acronym for Media Access Control, which is a hardware address that uniquely identifies network adapters or network interface cards (NIC). This is assigned by the manufacturer for identification, and used in the Media Access Control protocol sub-layer. It is also known as an Ethernet Hardware Address or physical address. To know the MAC address of your NIC, in Linux you can check the output of the `ifconfig` command. It displays information of all network interfaces along with their MAC addresses. Run the following command as the root:

```
ifconfig | grep HWaddr
```

Q I have a HP Pavilion DV2401TU laptop with a Broadcom 802.11b/g bcm4311 wireless adaptor. I tried to

configure it on Linux (Mandriva, Red Hat, SUSE, Linux Mint) using ndiswrapper and patches from the Net, as per instructions. But nothing has worked till now. Please help me out here. What about the availability of wireless adaptors that are fully compatible with Linux? Kindly provide an apt solution for the problem.

—vik01@itimes.com

The Broadcom wireless LAN card is not supported out-of-the-box in Linux but you can surely configure it. Connect to the Internet using a wired interface and install some software.

For OpenSUSE, a 1-click install YMP file (YaST Metapackage file) is available from Packman. To install this, go to <http://packman.links2linux.org/> and search for *broadcom-wl*. Click on the '1-click install' icon and follow the on-screen instructions. To get it working on Mint 5, you can follow the instructions given at www.linuxmint.com/wiki/index.php/Broadcom_bcm43xx. As for Fedora and Mandriva, it's available in the RPM Fusion and Mandriva non-free repositories, respectively. You can find a list of Linux-supported wireless adaptors at <http://linux-wless.passys.nl>.

Q I have an Intel Core 2 Duo system with 2 GB of RAM and a 160 GB HDD. I had installed Mandriva along with Windows XP. The system was working fine till I tried to install Fedora 11 from a live CD. After installing it, I am unable to boot any of my OS. I think there is some problem with my MBR, as

now whenever I boot, I get a message that says "Non-system disk or disk error. Replace and strike any key when ready". I have checked my BIOS and it recognises my HDD. Is the error due to HDD failure or is it due to some problem with the MBR?

—Milind Soneja

It seems that you have a bad boot loader. Just try installing GRUB from any live CD.

Q I have installed Fedora and have created different users and groups. Is it possible to add a new user to a specific group? Also, let me know how to change an existing user's group.

—Vikas Jha

To add a user to a specific group, you need to use the command given below:

```
# useradd -G <specific_group_name> <username>
```

For example, if you have a group called *accounts* and you want to add a user account to it, then, issue the following command:

```
# useradd -G accounts accounts
```

This will add the user *accounts* to the group *accounts*, provided there already exists a group called "accounts". Otherwise you need to create the group first.

To modify an existing user you can use the following command:

```
# usermod -a -G <group name> <user to be modified>
```

